they would fail in their effort, they would struggle to bend and reach under the table in search of their missing footwear, to the amusement of the rest of the room.

Krishna Kumar recalled yet another instance of Ratan going to great lengths to play a prank on Jamshed Bhabha, the brother of the nuclear physicist Homi Jehangir Bhabha and the founder of the National Centre for Performing Arts. Jamshed was a director in Tata Sons along with Ratan in the early 1990s. During a board meeting Ratan decided to fix a water pistol under the table and position it accurately to deliver its spurts where Bhabha would be seated. The directors' chairs were earmarked in advance so Ratan knew where to aim his pistol. He reached the boardroom early to fix the device.

An alert bearer accosted an unidentifiable man bending over with his head and half his body under the table only to discover that it was the chairman! The bearer's discovery spread like a flash and everybody was amused that Ratan was caught with the proverbial smoking gun, or rather a leaking water pistol. An embarrassed chairman fumbled for excuses while a highly relieved Bhabha thanked his luck for not having to walk out of the meeting wearing wet pants.

Ratan often pulled tricks on his sisters too. Shireen narrates an incident from around 1980 when they were staying with Ratan in his flat in Bakhtavar. Deanna was working in Delhi and Ratan had gone there for work and convinced her to return to Bombay with him. He had neither told his mother nor Shireen that she was returning with him to Bombay.

After arriving at the flat, at Ratan's prodding, Deanna tiptoed and hid in the bathtub. His mother and Shireen who were there at home joined him in his bedroom as they often did, especially after he returned from a trip, to chat and catch up on the highlights of his visit. Ratan requested Shireen to go fetch something from the bathroom and when she went in, she saw Deanna lying in the tub and she let out quite a yell, which had Ratan and Deanna convulsing, and his mother baffled.

Daring Pursuits

Those who do not know Ratan well would never associate him with adventurousness. He does not wear courage on his sleeve or look like the derring-do kind. But he does daring acts unhesitatingly. Perhaps, he has